

could combine the best of GNOME and KDE.

From the usability point of view, GNU/Linux is not hard to use. Those who have used it recently would agree. Why, now you even have pre-packaged software just like .exe files, which you can click and install. Go to GetDeb and you will see what I am talking about.

Next in line

The second thing that Dell should do is tie up with players like Adobe and the rest to provide binaries for high-end software like CS4, et al, to fill in the remaining gaps.

The parallel movement to open source everything can continue without having GNU/Linux users whine or compromise when it is about something they have to complete within this lifetime. For example, if I have to edit movies, I can't wait till I'm 40 for some efficient free software that can do the job.

If there are binaries of the desired programs, I can buy the licence and use it on a GNU/Linux machine. In which case, even hard-core media professionals will be rushing to buy Dell machines running GNU/Linux instead of Macs. Or, at least, there will be some healthy competition.

Support

There is a strong GNU/Linux community out there, so Dell won't have to worry much about support. You will probably get better community support for GNU/Linux, compared to Windows or Mac support—google for it and you will know. Home users rarely buy support, and then with a strong community, much of Dell's problems are already solved. As for some minor issues on GNU/Linux machines relating to device driver support, since they're Dell's machines, all hardware can be supported. In fact, Dell can optimise the operating system so as to get the best out of the hardware, whether it be longer battery life for laptops or a much better overall user experience.

For corporate users, Dell can tie up with open source vendors to offer its customers various levels of support.

This will also create a healthy market for support which hitherto is being controlled by a few.

Invest money in the right place

The money Dell pays to Microsoft for the Windows licence can be used in customising Ubuntu. And since Ubuntu has a new development cycle of six months, Ubuntu will sport new features and looks more frequently than the Mac—do I need to even mention Windows here?

Don't imitate a bad Apple

There's one caveat for Dell. Don't make anything proprietary. Except for the binaries for non-free stuff like CS4, Ubuntu must release the code for everything they improve upon so that the community keeps on building on top of it, and Ubuntu keeps on improving in the process.

This will enable Dell to create a unique proposition by getting extremely popular among GNU/Linux users, since sometimes, despite all the philosophy about freedom, Apple's

Mac does tempt them. But with Ubuntu, they will be able to showcase their shiny machines too!

Going forward

Gradually, with Dell becoming the most secure and popular GLPC (GNU/Linux Personal Computer), all the independent hardware manufacturers will also start rolling out open source hardware and drivers for their tiny whiny devices, so that they can run on the world's most popular operating system.

Those players will soon learn the beauty of open source—even if you have some bugs and less technical capabilities, the huge community is more than willing to take care of it, sooner than later.

This would lead to a phenomenon of releasing source code for hitherto proprietary technologies. Except for a few cases, it can also drive even the hard-core proprietary companies to start releasing specifications and code for their products.

The fear factor

Releasing code doesn't mean competitors will steal the show. Look at KDE and GNOME, Joomla and Drupal, or OpenOffice.org and the rest, as well as MySQL and PostgreSQL—despite the code being available, it's not that one is copying the other. Each has its own merits and they operate in a healthy competitive environment.

Then, since RMS is around with GPL, no one need worry about code being stolen and used, except for BSD-like stuff where Apple steals a lot from and returns almost zilch. Ironically, it charges heavily for what was initially developed by the community, and then puts such heavy locks on it that no one can peep inside. Don't forget, for every little problem, you have to visit an Apple Store and pay heavily.

It's the right time, Dell!

This seems to be the right time for Dell. Vista is taking its last breath. PC market share is falling. Should Dell wait and put its fate in the hands of another company and have no say in the software being used on its machines, or should it take control of everything that runs on its machines and become the No. 1 player in the world?

Dell can create history. All the other players, like HP, Lenovo, Asus and Acer, lack the extra muscle Dell has—customisation of hardware, the look and feel, and the desire to address the needs of end users. I don't think they have platforms like Dell Ideastorm, where they listen to what customers want.

Dell can do a lot. It can be the next 'sweet' Apple. But, the question is: can Dell hear the door bell?

The clock is ticking and Apple is closing in. 

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A Free Software fund-a-mental-ist and Charles Bukowski fan, Swapnil also writes fiction and tries to find cracks in a proprietary company's 'paper armours'. He is a big movie buff, and prefers listening to music at such loud volumes that he's gone partially deaf when it comes to identifying anything positive about proprietary companies. Oh, and he is also the assistant editor of *EFYTimes.com*.